

See also: The Representation of the People Act 188–189 ■ The Universal Declaration of Human Rights 222–229
 ■ The European Convention on Human Rights 230–233 ■ The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights 256–257



had mixed fairly freely until the 1880s, when some state legislatures then required railroads to provide separate carriages for “Negro” and “colored” passengers.

Protests began immediately, and in 1892, train passenger Homer Plessy refused to sit in the carriage reserved for black people. Plessy, who described himself as “seven-eighths Caucasian and one-eighth African blood,” was arrested. The case went to the Supreme Court, which, in 1896, ruled that state governments could indeed separate people racially, as long as all races were given equal facilities. It was a hammer blow. This “separate but equal” principle gave states freedom to continue segregation, and this division lasted for almost 60 years.

Black people were sent to separate schools, worked separately, traveled separately on trains and buses, and were seated separately in restaurants. The facilities for black people were far inferior to those for white people, despite the equality

Separate waiting rooms, dining areas, water fountains, and entrances were commonplace, while some establishments didn’t even permit black people on the premises at all.

principle—for example, school buses were provided for white children, while black children had to walk to school.

Continued discrimination

America’s entry into World War II in 1941 saw a million black men and women serve their country in defense of democracy and freedom. Yet they still faced discrimination when they returned. In 1948, President Harry Truman outlawed discrimination in the military, and the civil rights movement began to gain momentum.

In the 1950s, civil rights activists made their first real breakthrough. Founded in 1909,

the National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP) was patiently developing its legal challenges to segregation laws in public schools. In Topeka, Kansas, the board of education refused to allow Linda Brown, daughter of black resident Oliver Brown, to attend her local school, instead insisting she take a bus to the black elementary school across town. The NAACP stepped in and filed a case against Topeka on behalf of Oliver Brown.

The NAACP argued that schools for black children were not as good as the white schools. It also stated that segregation violated the clause in the Fourteenth Amendment, which holds that no state can “deny to any person within its jurisdiction the equal protection of the laws.” The case went with four others to the Supreme Court as *Brown v. Board of Education of Topeka*. The »

Prior to 1954, even in schools, racial segregation was obligatory in many states in the South. In the North, it tended to be outlawed or in limited use.

